

# EVOLVING CULTURAL PARADIGMS

Biological evolution supplies only a rough analogy for cultural evolution, but offers illuminating parallels. Within cultures, successful ideas or ‘memes’ are reproduced and passed between people. Like genes, memes aren’t selected on their own — rather they come together in packages, groups of ideas, like DNA. Like biological species, examples of these cultural codes vary in their attributes. Different societies throughout history have shared similar **base cultural paradigms** comprising particular sets of core views and values.

## Punctuated equilibria

Scholars and theorists of cultural evolution observe a historic tendency for cultural paradigms to change over centuries. Like genetic evolution, paradigms display punctuated equilibria — periods of stasis punctuated by shifts that are gradual to begin with and then, beyond a tipping point, abrupt. Paradigm shifts entail widespread adoption of radically different worldviews and values, with transformative consequences for humanity’s behavior and relationship with the world. However, the ideas that will characterize the next paradigm often form *before* the shift itself.

**Fig. 1**  
Features of the pre-modern, modern and post-modern paradigms.

|                                | Pre-Modern                                                                                                      | Modern                                                                                                                                | Post-Modern                                                                                                                                                                            |
|--------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Art                            | <p><b>One perspective</b><br/> <small>Single truth, single cultural truth (shared story, tradition)</small></p> | <p><b>Perspective</b><br/> <small>Single, "true" view</small></p>                                                                     | <p><b>Multiple Perspective</b></p>                                                                                                                                                     |
| Social Structures              | <p><b>Hierarchy</b><br/> <small>Authority, duty</small></p>                                                     | <p><b>Individualism and Freedom</b><br/> <small>Personalism ... Individualism ...</small></p>                                         | <p><b>Inclusivity, Cultural Relativism</b><br/> <small>Unity, unity, multiculturalism</small></p>                                                                                      |
| Economic Structures (Concepts) | <p><b>Feudal</b><br/> <small>Tied to land, Communal</small></p>                                                 | <p><b>Capitalism and Commodities</b><br/> <small>Profit, private property, market, individualism ... Authority with force</small></p> | <p><b>Signs and Information</b><br/> <small>Purpose, intent, material, awareness, awareness by objects/idea, Purpose, all signs and information are arbitrary, all meaning</small></p> |
| Episteme                       | <p><b>Revealed Truth via Religion</b></p>                                                                       | <p><b>Reveal and Science</b></p>                                                                                                      | <p><b>Multiple valid perspectives</b><br/> <small>As "Truth"</small></p>                                                                                                               |
| Center of Concern              | <p><b>God</b></p>                                                                                               | <p><b>Man</b></p>                                                                                                                     | <p><b>Ecosystem</b></p>                                                                                                                                                                |
| Authority comes from ...       | <p><b>God and King</b></p>                                                                                      | <p><b>The People</b><br/> <small>(Who discovered via Reason)</small><br/> <small>1 commands, 2 responds</small></p>                   | <p><b>It</b><br/> <small>(Who authority?)</small></p>                                                                                                                                  |
| Valued / Worried               |                                                                                                                 | <p><b>Being Right</b></p>                                                                                                             | <p><b>Feeling good, Healing</b></p>                                                                                                                                                    |
| Zone of Concern                | <p><b>Things</b><br/> <small>can be measured e.g. collection</small></p>                                        | <p><b>Action</b></p>                                                                                                                  | <p><b>World to All Acting</b></p>                                                                                                                                                      |

Influential among such frameworks is the **Spiral Dynamics** model, which has evolved from the early work of Clare Graves via Beck and Cowan into the popular synthesis by Ken Wilber and the Integral movement.

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**Fig. 2**  
Features of the pre-modern, modern and post-modern paradigms.

|                                | Pre-Modern                                                                                | Modern                                                                                                                   | Post-Modern                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|--------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Art                            | As perspective<br><small>Being, truth and cultural events layered over each other</small> | Perspective<br><small>Single, "true" eye</small>                                                                         | Multiple Perspective                                                                                                                                                                        |
| Social Structures              | Hierarchy<br><small>Authority built</small>                                               | Individualism and Progress<br><small>Results in individualism</small>                                                    | Inclusivity, Cultural Relativism<br><small>Unity, truth, progress</small>                                                                                                                   |
| Economic Structures (Concepts) | Feudal<br><small>Trade and Commerce</small>                                               | Capitalism and Commodities<br><small>Profit, growth, control, surplus, knowledge, productivity, efficiency, etc.</small> | Signs and Information<br>Purpose, Self-Organizing?<br><small>Purpose, intent, material, processes, development, by objectives, purpose, all signs and information, efficiency, etc.</small> |
| Episteme                       | Revealed Truth via Religion                                                               | Power and Secrecy                                                                                                        | Multiple valid perspectives as "truth"                                                                                                                                                      |
| Center of Concern              | God                                                                                       | Man                                                                                                                      | Ecosystem                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| Authority comes from ...       | God and King                                                                              | The People<br><small>Truth discovered via Reason, consensus, democracy</small>                                           | It<br><small>Who authority?</small>                                                                                                                                                         |
| Valued / Worshipped            |                                                                                           | Being Right                                                                                                              | Feeling good, Healing                                                                                                                                                                       |
| Zone of Concern                | Things<br><small>can be measured e.g. Creation</small>                                    | Action                                                                                                                   | World to All Actions                                                                                                                                                                        |

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**Fig. 3**  
Features of the pre-modern, modern and post-modern paradigms.

|                                | Pre-Modern                                                                                | Modern                                                                                                | Post-Modern                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|--------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Art                            | No perspective<br><small>Static, both inner and outer worlds<br/>(space and time)</small> | Perspective<br><small>Single, "true" view</small>                                                     | Multiple Perspective                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Social Structures              | Hierarchy<br><small>Authority<br/>Status</small>                                          | Individualism and Progress<br><small>Democracy<br/>Individualism ...</small>                          | Inclusivity, Cultural Relativism<br><small>Critique, chaos<br/>Relativism</small>                                                                                                                         |
| Economic Structures (Concepts) | Feudal<br><small>Trade is bad<br/>Commerce</small>                                        | Capitalism and Commodities<br><small>Profit, growth, control<br/>Market<br/>Individualism ...</small> | Signs and Information<br>Posters, so-forgettable?<br><small>Progress, rapid change<br/>Mass media (management) by objectives<br/>Primary of signs and information<br/>by advertising, who governs</small> |
| Episteme                       | Revealed Truth<br>via Religion                                                            | Reason and Science                                                                                    | Multiple valid perspectives<br>No "truth"                                                                                                                                                                 |
| Center of Concern              | God                                                                                       | Man                                                                                                   | Ecosystem                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| Authority comes from ...       | God and King                                                                              | The People<br><small>Truth discovered via Reason<br/>1 consensus, 2 democracy</small>                 | ??<br><small>Who authority?</small>                                                                                                                                                                       |
| Valued / Worried               |                                                                                           | Being Right                                                                                           | Feeling good, Healing                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| Zone of Concern                | Things<br><small>can be measured e.g. CRISTIAN</small>                                    | Motion                                                                                                | World to All Actions                                                                                                                                                                                      |

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**Fig. 4**  
Features of the pre-modern, modern and post-modern paradigms.

|                                | Pre-Modern                                                                                | Modern                                                                                                                               | Post-Modern                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|--------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Art                            | No perspective<br><small>Static, both inner and outer worlds<br/>(space and time)</small> | Perspective<br><small>Single, "true" view</small>                                                                                    | Multiple Perspective                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| Social Structures              | Hierarchy<br><small>Authority<br/>Status</small>                                          | Individualism and Progress<br><small>Democracy<br/>Individualism ...</small>                                                         | Inclusivity, Cultural Relativism<br><small>Critique, chaos<br/>Relativism</small>                                                                                                                           |
| Economic Structures (Concepts) | Feudal<br><small>Trade is bad<br/>Commerce</small>                                        | Capitalism and Commodities<br><small>Profit, growth, control<br/>Market<br/>Individualism ...<br/>Profit-making with freedom</small> | Signs and Information<br>Subjects, de-Framing/usage?<br><small>Progress, rapid cultural<br/>change, mass management by networks<br/>Primary of signs and information<br/>by technology, who governs</small> |
| Episteme                       | Revealed Truth<br>via Religion                                                            | Reason and Science                                                                                                                   | Multiple valid perspectives<br>No "Truth"                                                                                                                                                                   |
| Center of Concern              | God                                                                                       | Man                                                                                                                                  | Ecosystem                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| Authority comes from ...       | God and King                                                                              | The People<br><small>Truth discovered via Reason<br/>1 consensus, 2 consensus</small>                                                | ??<br><small>Who authority?</small>                                                                                                                                                                         |
| Valued / Wanted                |                                                                                           | Being Right                                                                                                                          | Feeling good, Healing                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| Zone of Concern                | Thing<br><small>can be measured e.g. objective</small>                                    | Motion                                                                                                                               | World to All Actions                                                                                                                                                                                        |

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